



WORLD CUP 26



RFEF · ESPAÑA

HOSTS

• Canada · Mexico · USA

FINAL

Spain **1–0** Argentina (aet)

DECIDER

F. Torres **106'**

TITLE

Second star · 16 years on

REPORT

ESP-WC26 · 01

A TOURNAMENT TOLD THROUGH DATA

Why Spain Won The *2026* World Cup

CAMPEONES DEL MUNDO

8

MATCHES

7.1

WINS · DRAW

14–1

GOALS FOR · AGAINST

7

CLEAN SHEETS

CREATED BY

Aymane Labtiti

Built end-to-end in Python · pandas + matplotlib

Logos are the property of FIFA and the RFEF and are used here for identification only.



The Road

Eight games, zero defeats

- GRP · Cape Verde
0-0
- GRP · Saudi Arabia
4-0 Yamal, Oyarzabal (2), Al Tambakti (og)
- GRP · Uruguay
1-0 Baena 42'
- R32 · Austria
3-0 Oyarzabal (2), Porro
- R16 · Portugal
1-0 Merino 90'
- QF · Belgium
2-1 F. Ruiz, Merino 88'
- SF · France
2-0 Oyarzabal (pen), Porro
- FINAL · Argentina
1-0 (aet) F. Torres 106'

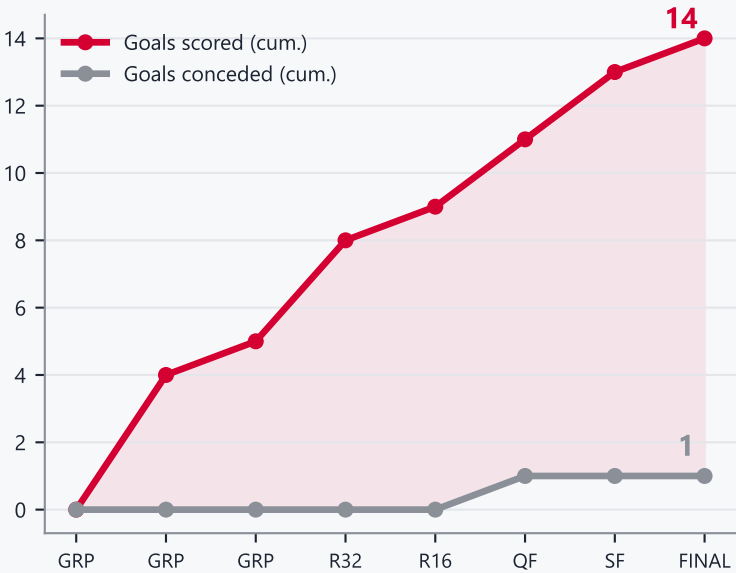
In Possession

Out of Possession

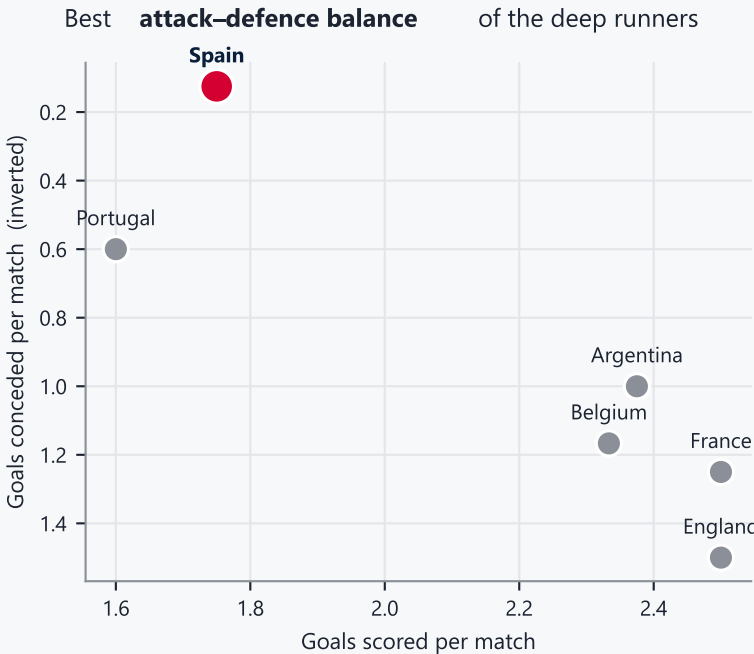
Scored 14, conceded 1

The Squad

Key Players



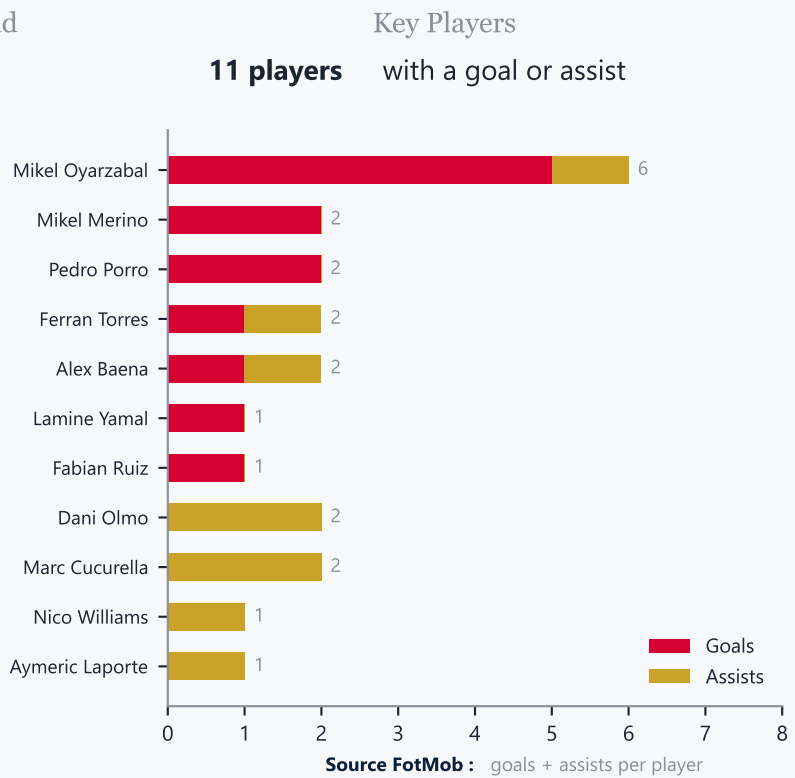
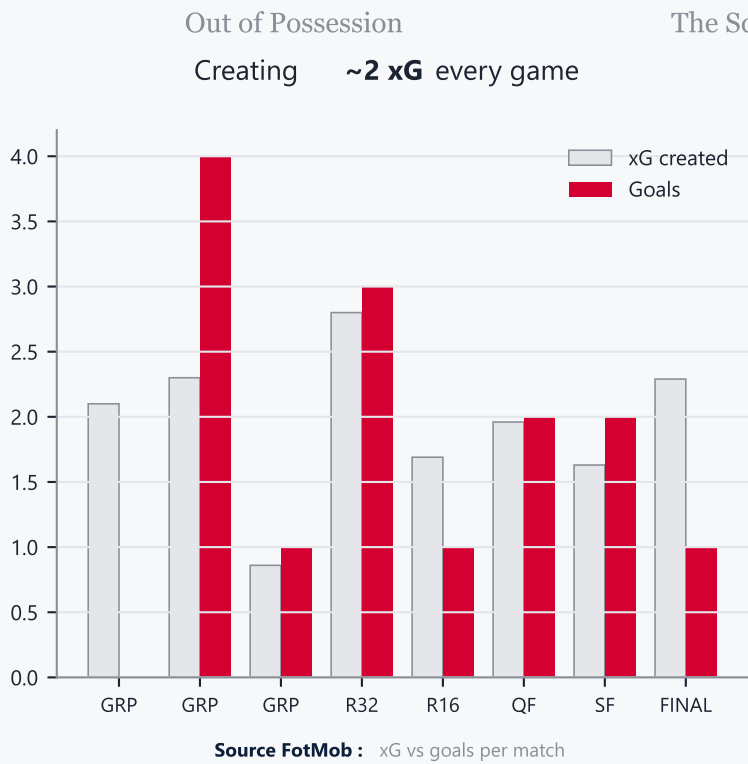
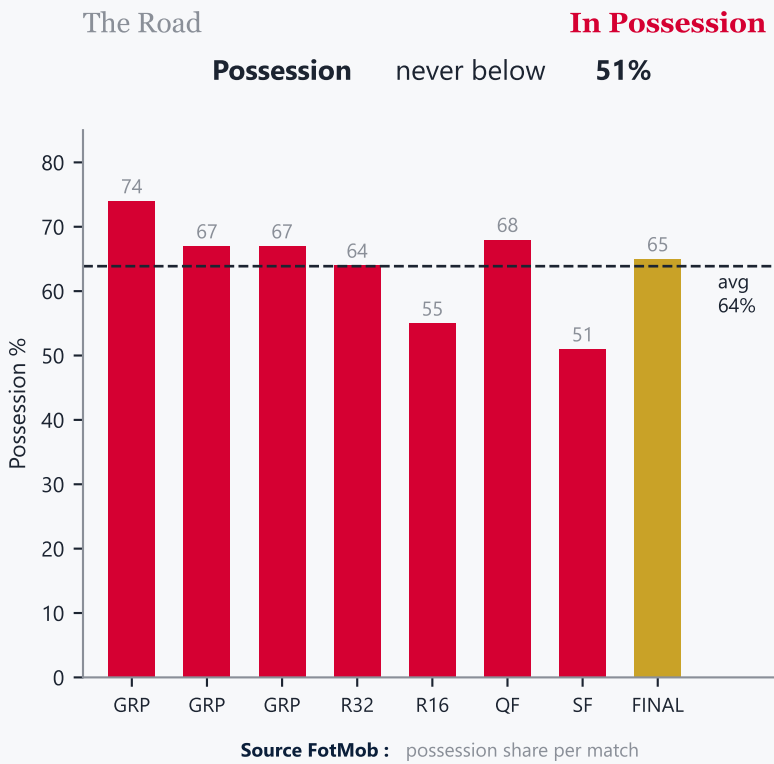
Source FIFA / ESPN : cumulative goals across the 8 matches



Source FotMob : per-match rates, Spain + the other deep runners

Spain's route was anything but soft: Uruguay in the group, then Portugal, Belgium, France and Argentina back-to-back in the knockouts — four top-10 sides eliminated in a row. The scoreline pattern is the story of the campaign: after a wasteful 0-0 against Cape Verde, Spain never dropped another point and never trailed at any moment of the tournament.

The attack-defence map on the right isolates why. Among every side that reached the last eight, Spain is alone in the top-right quadrant of the balance: 1.75 goals per game scored with just 0.13 conceded. Argentina and France matched the attacking rate — nobody came close to combining it with Spain's defensive record of a single goal in 750+ minutes.



Spain suffocated opponents with the ball before beating them with it. Possession never dipped below 51% — the semi-final against France was the only time it fell under 64% — and peaked at 74% in the opener. That control is a defensive weapon as much as an attacking one: FotMob's numbers show opponents never generated more than 0.63 xG in a match.

The chance-creation engine was remarkably steady: 15.6 expected goals across eight matches, roughly two per game regardless of opponent quality. Early wastefulness (0 goals from 2.1 xG vs Cape Verde) corrected itself as the tournament progressed. And crucially, the load was shared: Oyarzabal's five goals led the way, but eleven different players contributed a goal or an assist — full-back Porro and midfielder Merino chipping in from deep.

In Possession : Team Shape & Where The Threat Came From

The Road

Average touch positions

In Possession

— Rodri is the hub

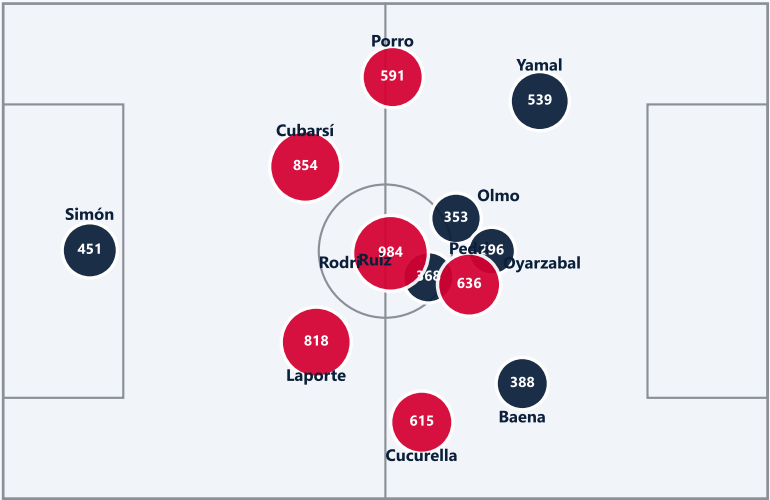
Out of Possession

Both flanks, rarely the middle

The Squad

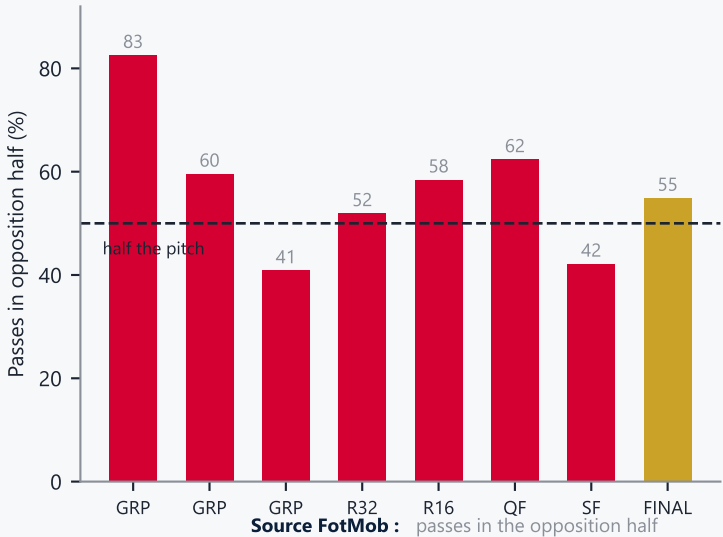
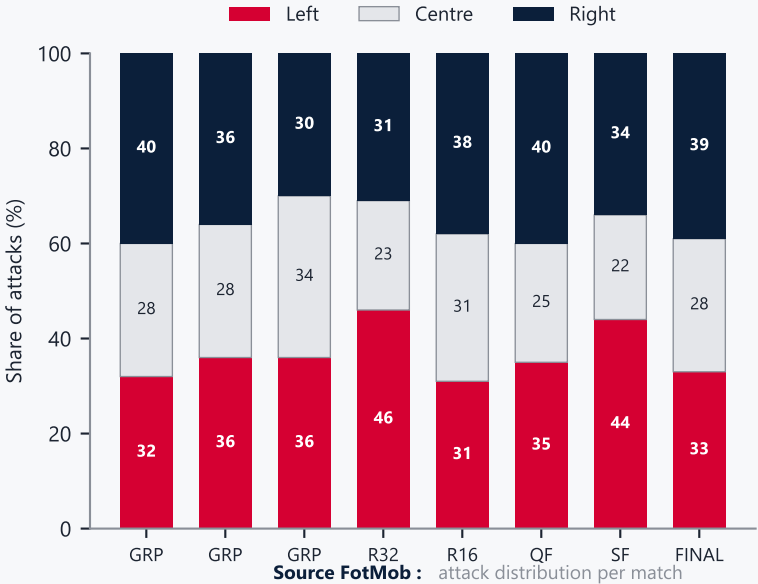
Key Players

The game played in their half



attacking direction →

Source FotMob : 7,724 real touches; node size = touch volume



How the goals came



The shape map is built from every touch Spain played: Rodri sits deepest and central with 984 of them, more than any teammate — the hub the whole structure turns through. Behind him Cubarsi and Laporte took 854 and 818, proof that the build-up genuinely started at the back; ahead, Cucurella and Porro push so high they sit level with the midfield.

The zone split kills a lazy assumption: this was not a left-sided team. Attacks were almost perfectly balanced — 37% left, 36% right, just 27% through the middle — and the emphasis moved with the opponent, swinging to 46% left against Austria and 44% against France. Territory tells the rest: in six of eight matches more than half of Spain's passes were played inside the opponent's half.

Goal DNA : The Build-Up Patterns Behind The Title

The Road

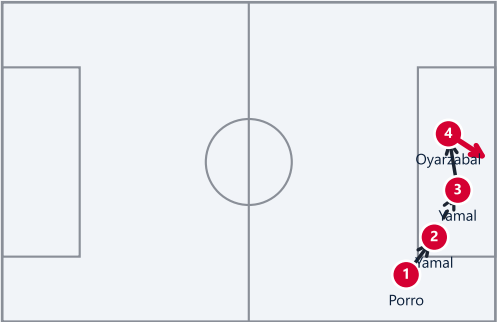
In Possession

Out of Possession

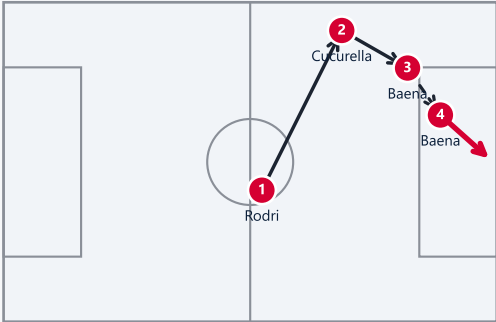
The Squad

Key Players

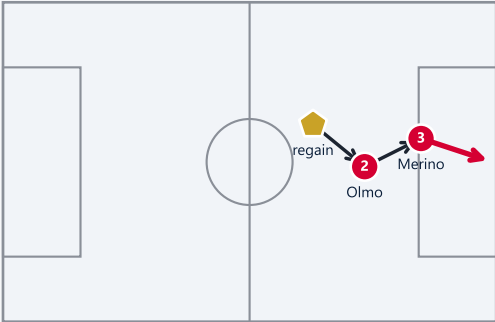
4-0 Saudi Arabia · wide overload



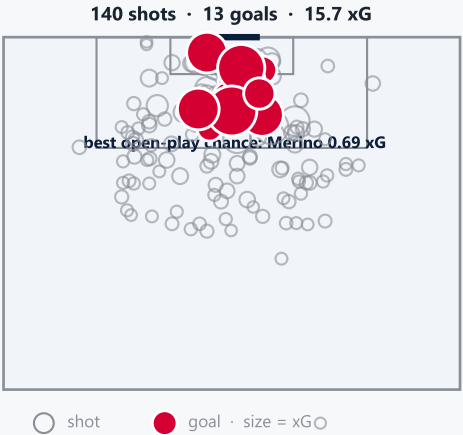
1-0 Uruguay · switch & cut inside



1-0 Portugal · counter-press strike, 90'

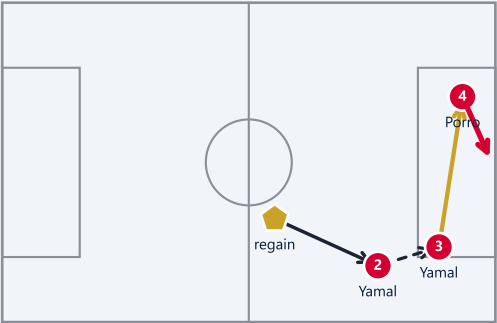


Where they actually shot — all 8 games

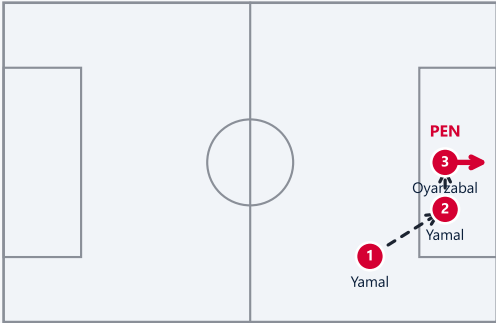


Source FotMob : every Spain shot, real coordinates

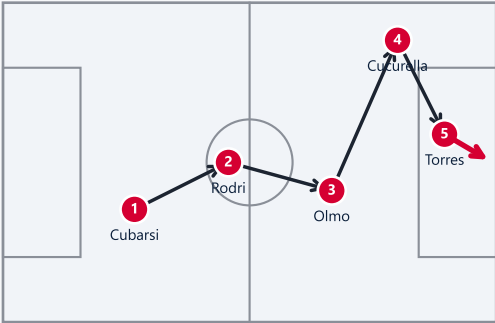
2-0 France · regain to far post



2-0 France · Yamal wins the pen

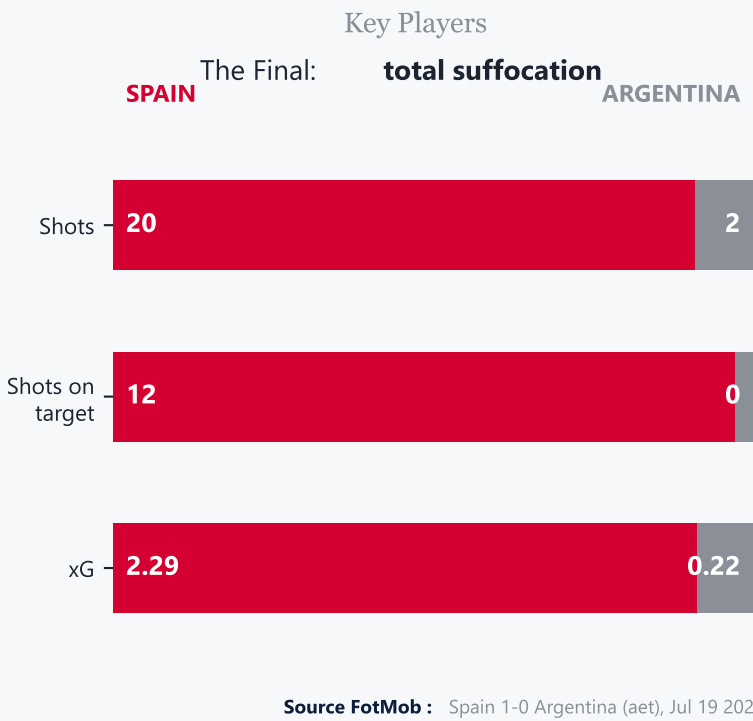
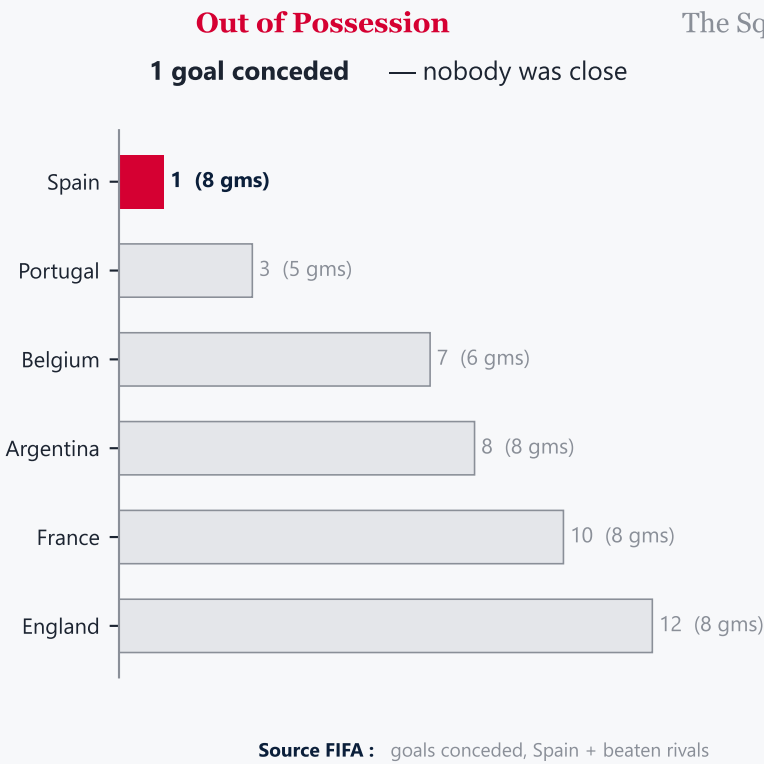
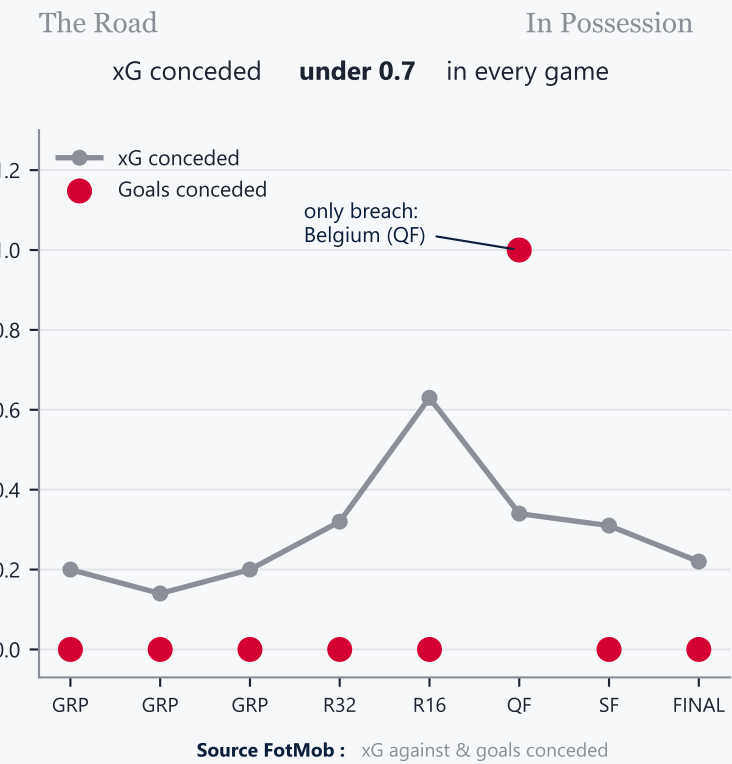


1-0 Argentina · the patient kill, 106'



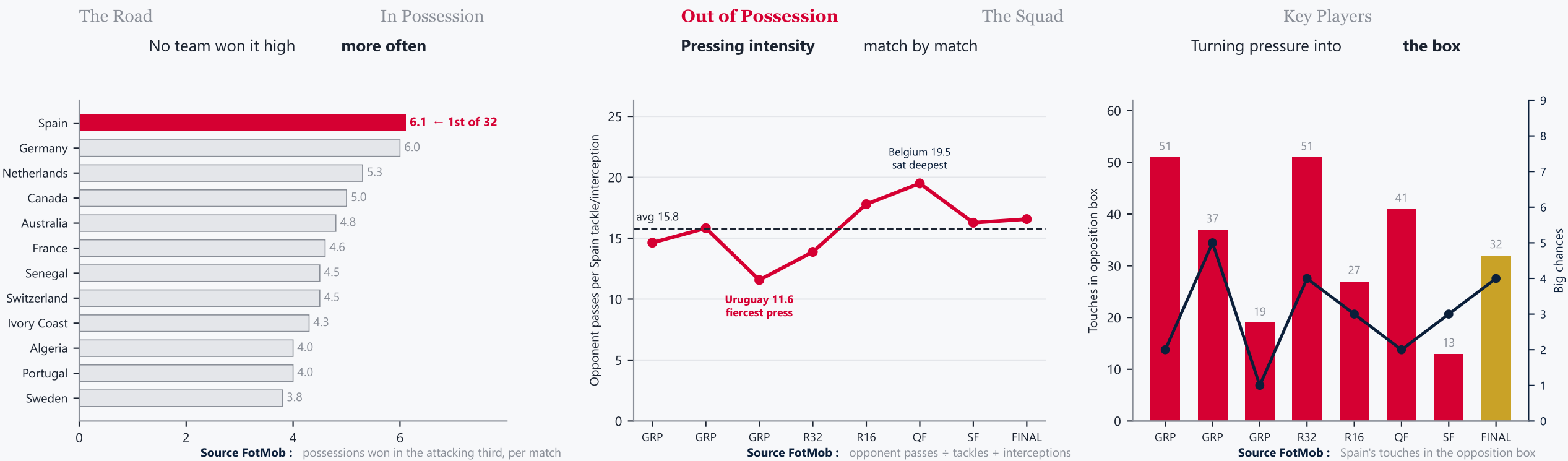
Six goals, four signatures — the wide overload and cutback, the switch to the weak side, the strike seconds after a regain, and the patient kill that decided the Final.

The real shot map behind them is just as revealing: 140 attempts worth 15.6 xG, almost all inside or on the edge of the box, and barely a speculative effort from distance. Eleven of the fourteen goals came from open play — one corner, one penalty, one own goal forced — and the highest-value open-play chance of the campaign was Merino's 0.69 xG winner against Belgium.



One goal against in eight matches — over 750 minutes of football — is one of the great defensive campaigns in World Cup history, and FotMob's data shows it was no accident of luck: xG conceded never reached 0.7 in any match, just 2.4 across the whole tournament. The only breach was De Ketelaere's header for Belgium in the quarter-final — answered by Merino within the same match. Unai Simon's seven clean sheets earned him the Golden Glove; 19-year-old Pau Cubarsi, the tournament's Best Young Player, anchored the back line throughout. The final distilled the whole identity. Spain out-shot Argentina 20-2 with twelve efforts on target to Argentina's none in regulation — Messi's side did not manage a single attempt until the 117th minute. Enzo Fernandez was sent off in second-half stoppage time, and Ferran Torres struck the winner in the 106th. 0.22 xG conceded in a World Cup final is domination in its purest form.

Out Of Possession : Winning The Ball Where It Hurts



Spain finished the tournament first of the 32 ranked sides for possessions won in the attacking third — 6.1 per match, a third more than the France side they beat in the semi-final and more than double Argentina's 2.9. That is the clearest number in this report: the champions did their defending in the opponent's territory, not their own.

The intensity was deliberately variable. Uruguay were pressed hardest — 11.6 opponent passes per Spanish tackle or interception, the fiercest squeeze of the campaign — while against Belgium, the one side to score against them, Spain sat off at 19.5 and paid for it. And the pressure converted into territory that mattered: 51 touches in the opposition box against both Cape Verde and Austria, and 32 in the Final, which turned into four big chances on a night Argentina created none.

The Road

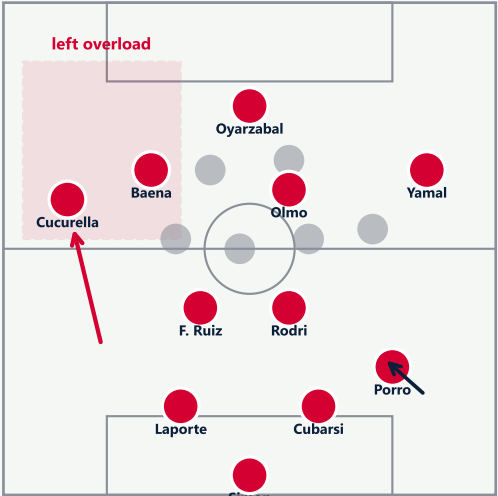
In Possession

Out of Possession

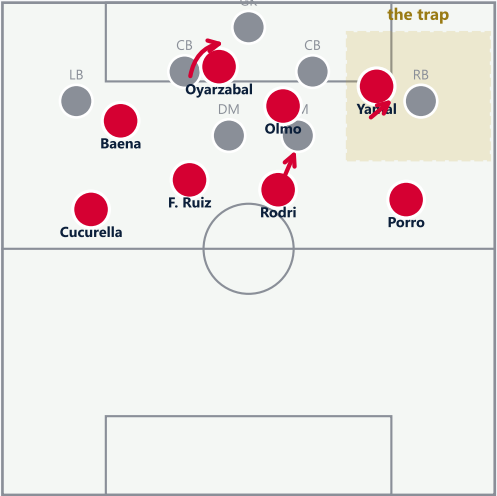
The Squad

Key Players

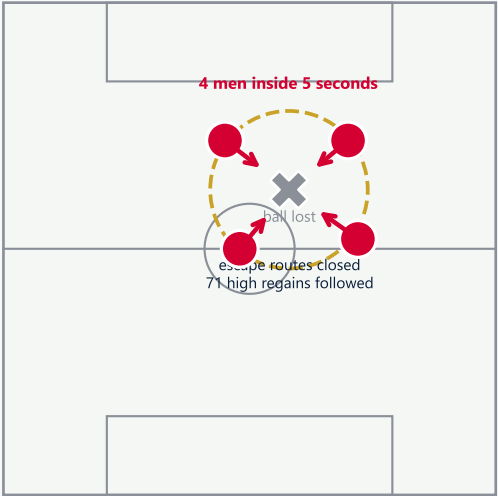
IN POSSESSION — the 3-2-5 build



OUT OF POSSESSION — the curve press



TRANSITION — the 5-second rule

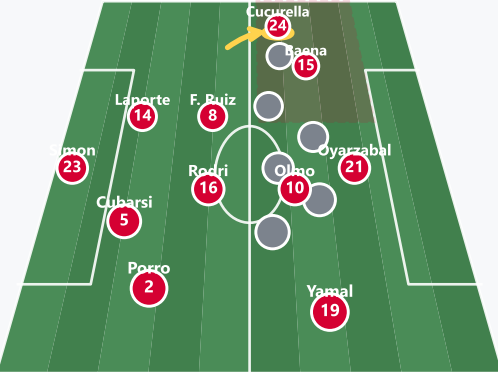


Three principles, each shown twice: the analyst's plan view on top, and the same moment through a virtual tactical camera below — the broadcast angle, reconstructed in code.

With the ball, Spain build a 3-2-5 that pins opponents in their own half — Cucurella releases while Porro tucks in.

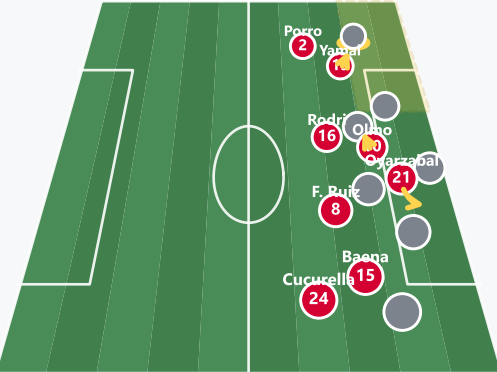
Without it, Oyarzabal's curved run hides the centre and shows the touchline, where the trap springs shut on the ringed full-back.

IN POSSESSION · 3-2-5 BUILD



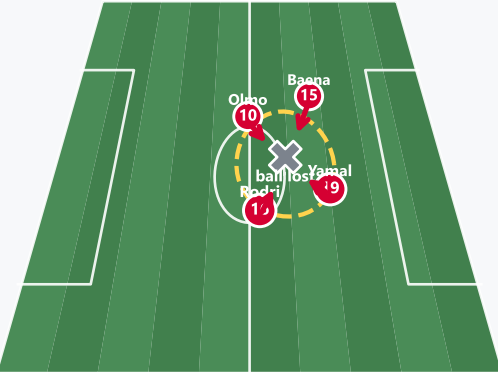
The camera view: the overload forms far side

OUT OF POSSESSION · THE TRAP



The camera view: the 9 curves, the trap waits

TRANSITION · 5-SECOND COLLAPSE



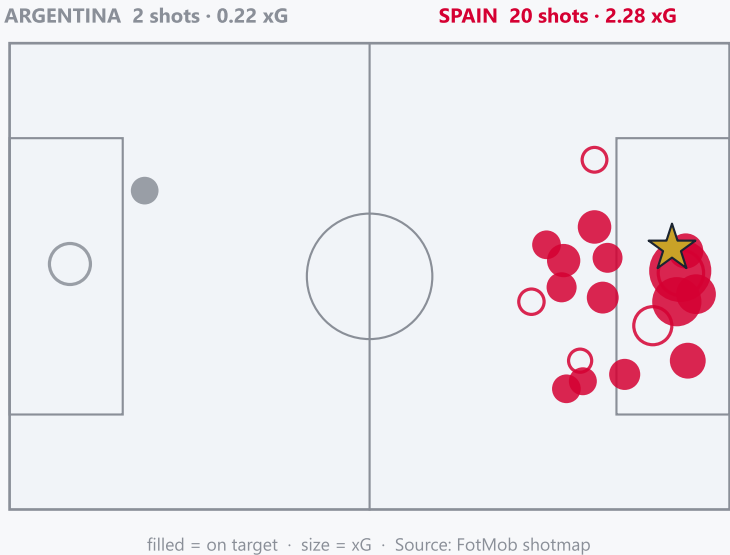
The camera view: four shirts, five seconds

And in the moment between, the nearest four collapse on the ball inside five seconds — the engine behind 71 high regains. Every phase is a territorial argument; Spain won it in all eight matches.

The Final Under The Microscope : Spain 1-0 Argentina (aet)

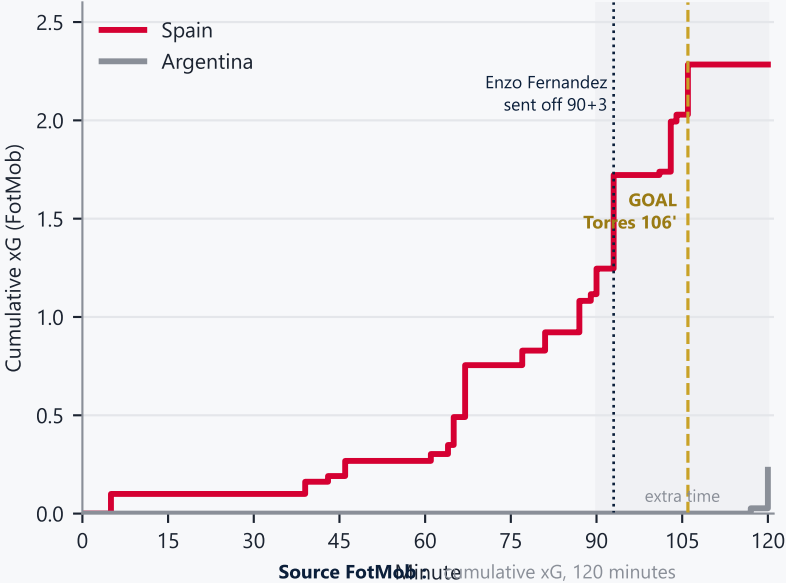
MetLife Stadium, July 19 2026 · real shot-by-shot data from FotMob: 20-2 shots, 12-0 on target, 2.29-0.22 xG

Every shot of the Final

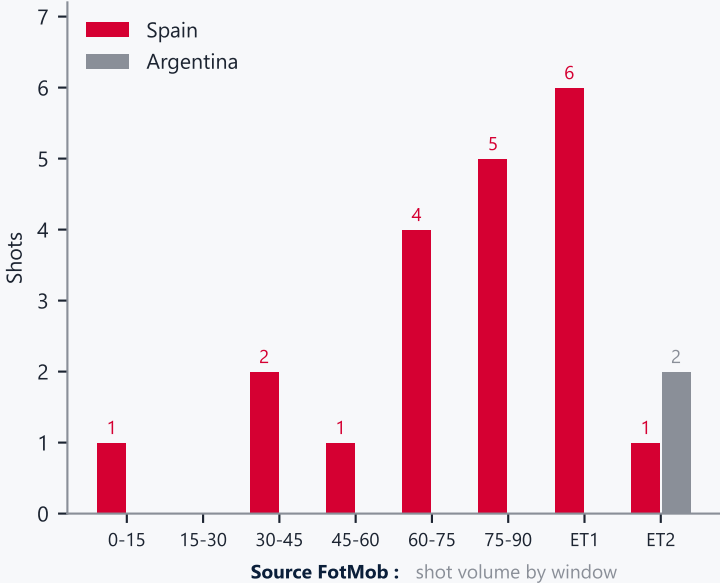


Source FotMob : shotmap — real coordinates & per-shot xG

The xG race — one-way traffic



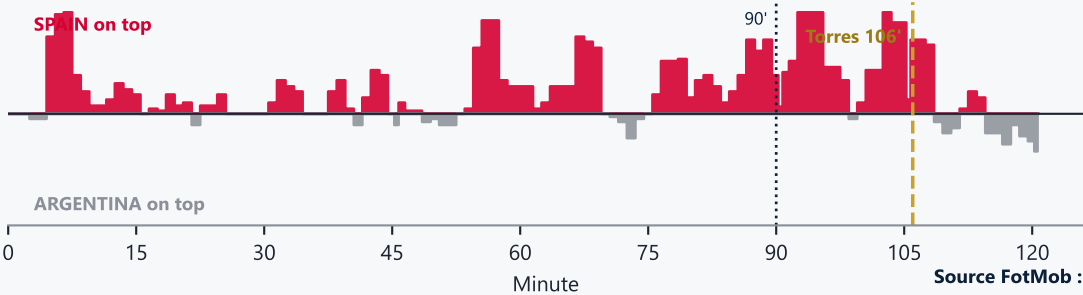
Shots per 15-minute window



The map shows a siege: Spain's twenty attempts ring the Argentine box, twelve on target, while Argentina did not attempt a single shot until the 117th minute — Messi's effort and a Simeone strike in the last seconds were all they mustered.

The xG race only ever climbs in red: 2.29 expected goals to 0.22. Then the dam broke twice in thirteen minutes — Enzo Fernandez's second yellow in stoppage time, and Ferran Torres finishing in the 106th the move the whole final had been building toward.

Match momentum — Spain on top almost throughout



The Squad : One XI, Sixteen Contributors

The Road

In Possession

Out of Possession

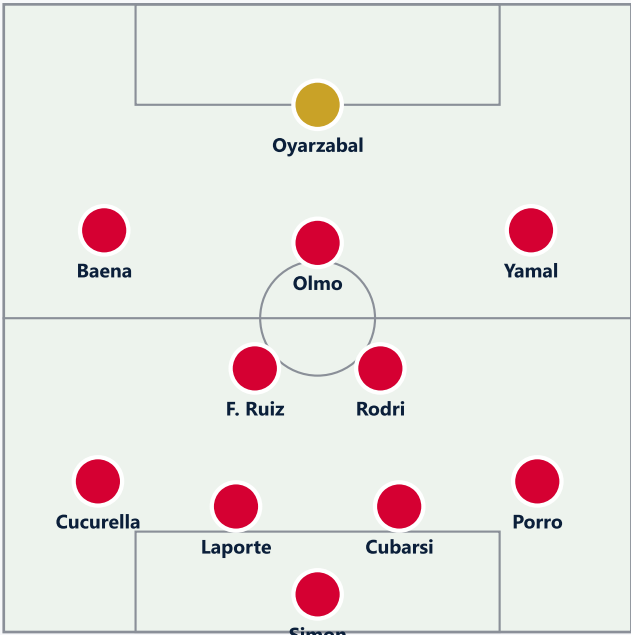
The Squad

Key Players

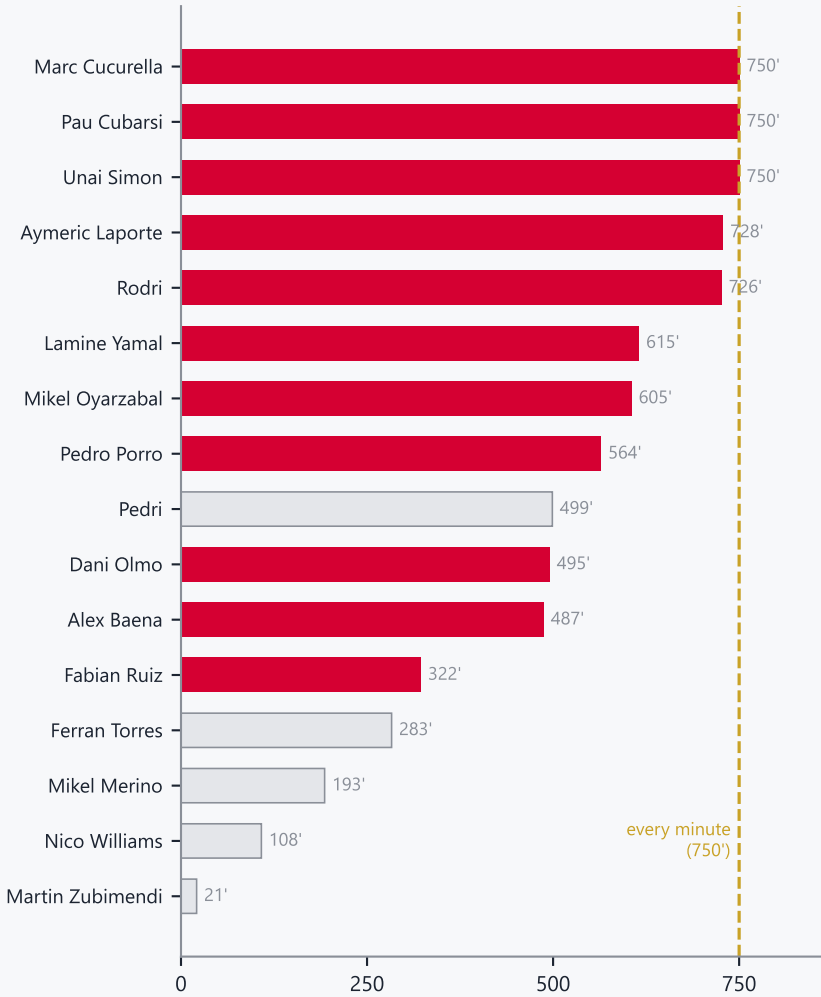
The Final XI (4-2-3-1)

Minutes — a settled spine, a deep bench

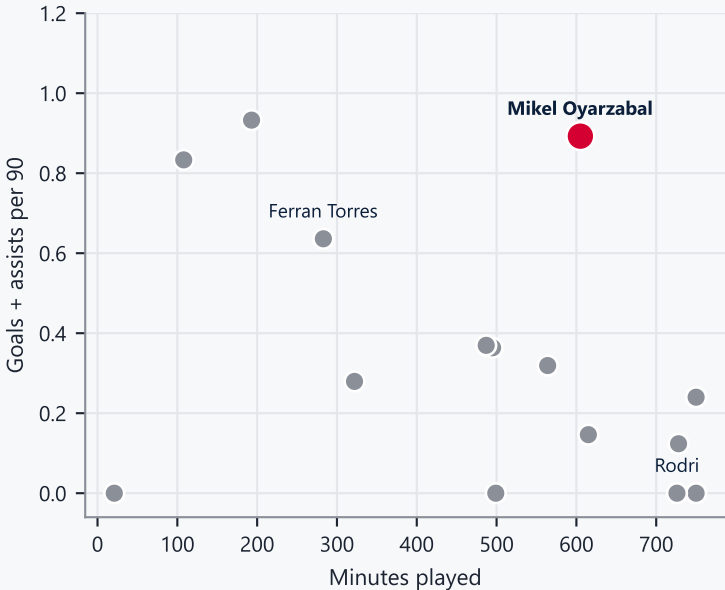
Production vs minutes played



Source SI / beIN : unchanged from the semi-final



Source FotMob : real minutes incl. extra time



Source FotMob : goal involvements per 90

De la Fuente found his best XI by the semi-final and never touched it again — the same eleven started against France and Argentina. Four men were on the pitch for all or almost all of the 750+ minutes: Simon, Cubarsi, Cucurella and Laporte.

The scatter shows the two kinds of contributor: the volume producer (Oyarzabal, 6 goal involvements) and the surgical substitutes — Merino's two knockout winners came in just 193 minutes, a goal involvement rate no starter matched.

The Road

In Possession

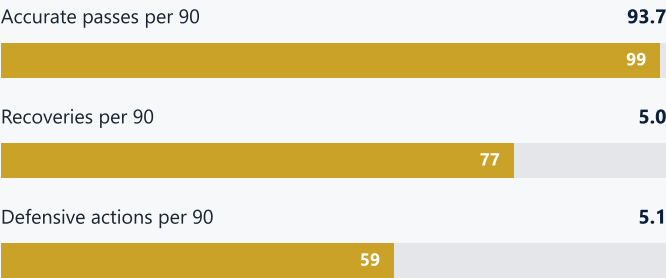
Out of Possession

The Squad

Key Players

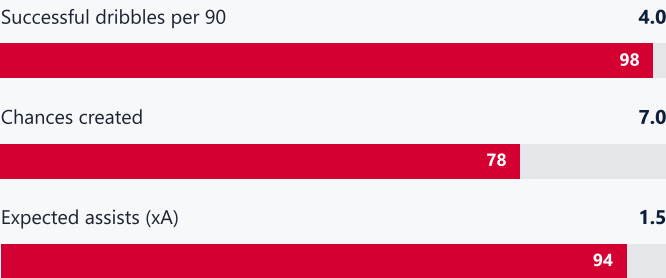
Rodri

DM - Golden Ball winner



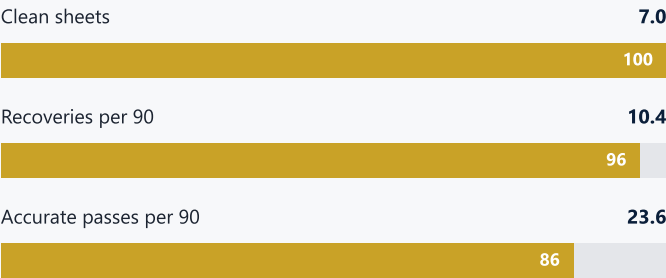
Lamine Yamal

RW - 19 years old



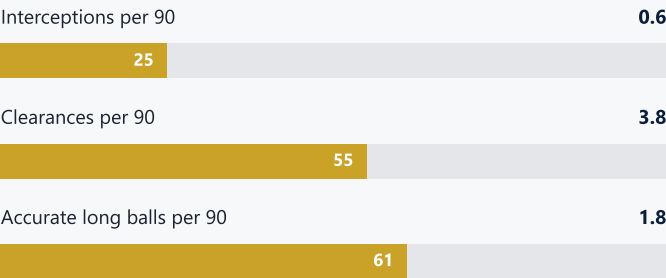
Unai Simon

GK - Golden Glove winner



Pau Cubarsi

CB - Best Young Player (19)



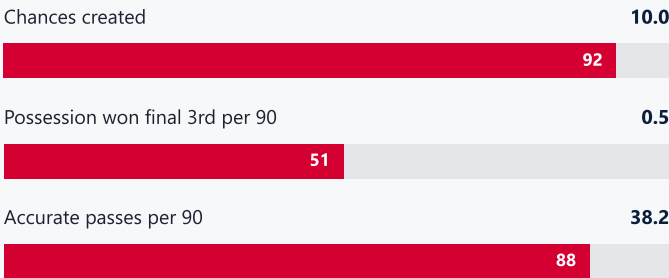
Mikel Oyarzabal

ST - Spain top scorer



Dani Olmo

AM - the pocket finder



Every value is real FotMob data. Each bar is the player's true percentile against WC26 players in the same position group who played 180+ minutes (gold = award winner).

The Road

In Possession

Out of Possession

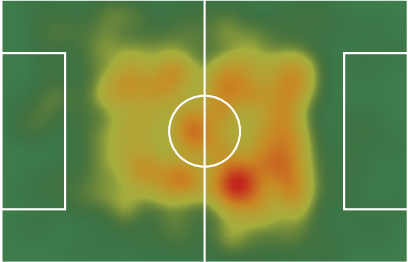
The Squad

Key Players



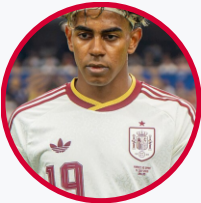
Rodri

DM · Golden Ball



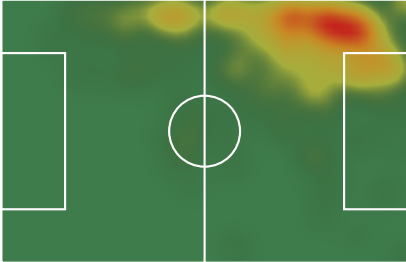
984 touches, most in the squad · 93.7 accurate passes per 90

Heatmap computed from 984 real touches (FotMob match heatmaps)



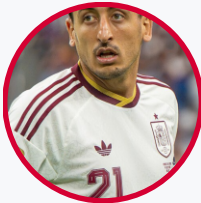
Lamine Yamal

RW · 19 years old



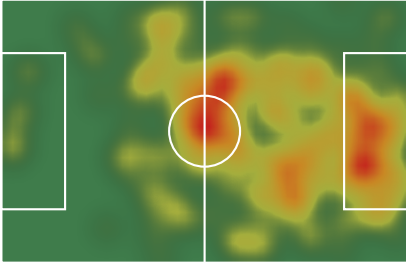
4.0 successful dribbles per 90 · 1.5 xA, 7 chances created

Heatmap computed from 539 real touches (FotMob match heatmaps)



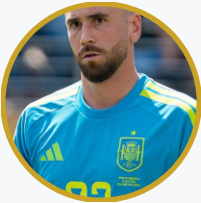
Mikel Oyarzabal

ST · top scorer



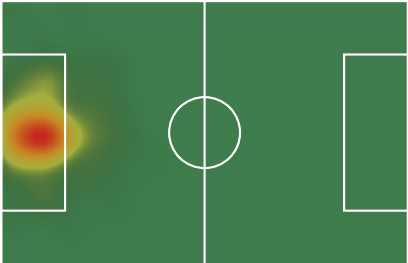
5 goals from 4.0 xG · scored in four different matches

Heatmap computed from 296 real touches (FotMob match heatmaps)



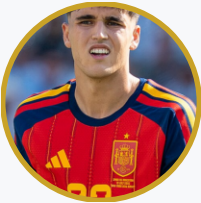
Unai Simon

GK · Golden Glove



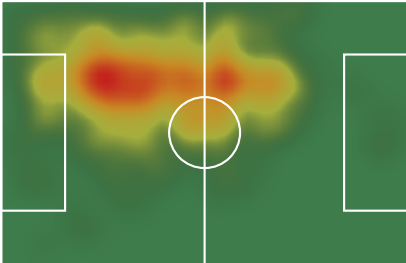
7 clean sheets in 8 · 10.4 recoveries per 90, 2nd at WC26

Heatmap computed from 451 real touches (FotMob match heatmaps)



Pau Cubarsi

CB · Best Young Player



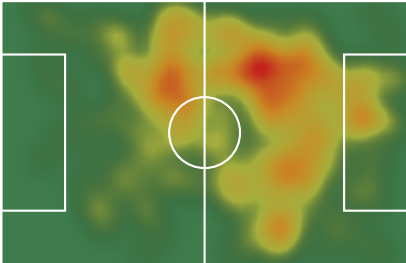
854 touches at 19 · more than any defender in the squad

Heatmap computed from 854 real touches (FotMob match heatmaps)



Dani Olmo

AM · the pocket finder



10 chances created · 92nd percentile among WC26 at

Heatmap computed from 353 real touches (FotMob match heatmaps)

The One That Got Away : England, The Champion Spain Never Met

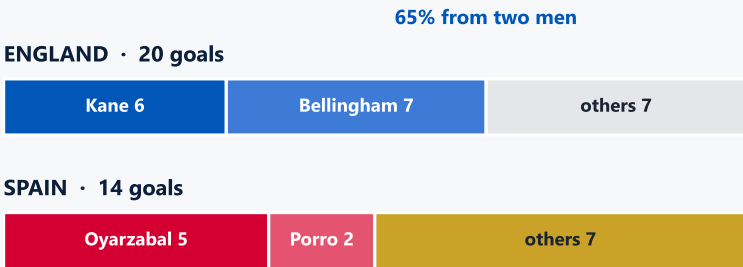
Third place · the only heavyweight missing from Spain's route · eliminated by Argentina at 90+2 in the semi-final

6W 1D 1L — 20 scored, 12 conceded

Two ways to build an attack

Head to head by the numbers

- **GRP · Croatia**
4–2 Kane (2), Bellingham, Rashford
- **GRP · Ghana**
0–0
- **GRP · Panama**
2–0 Bellingham, Kane
- **R32 · DR Congo**
2–1 Kane (2) - from a goal down
- **R16 · Mexico**
3–2 Bellingham (2), Kane - with 10 men
- **QF · Norway**
2–1 Bellingham (2)
- **SF · Argentina**
1–2 Gordon - Lautaro wins it 90+2
- **3RD · France**
6–4 Bronze final

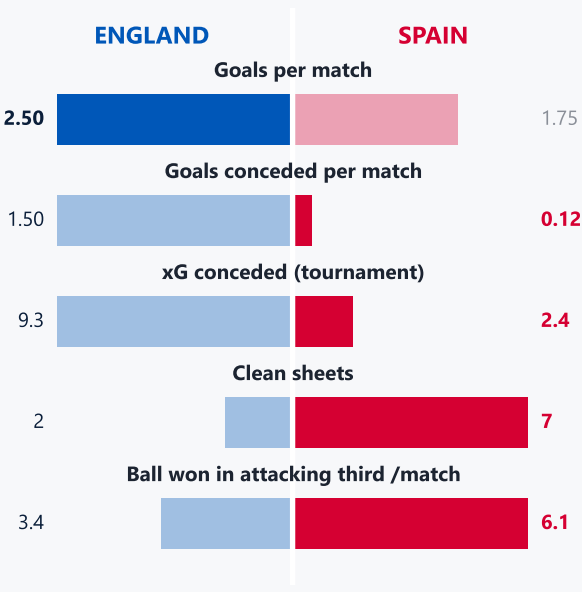


50% from two men — and 11 contributors in total

Source belN / englandfootball.com : Kane 6 + Bellingham 7, first 6+6 duo in WC history

England were the tournament's heaviest scorers — 20 goals, more than Spain — powered by the deadliest partnership a World Cup has ever seen: Kane and Bellingham became the first teammates to reach six goals each in a single edition. On raw firepower, they were the one side that could out-gun anyone, and their 6-4 bronze-final win over France showed it.

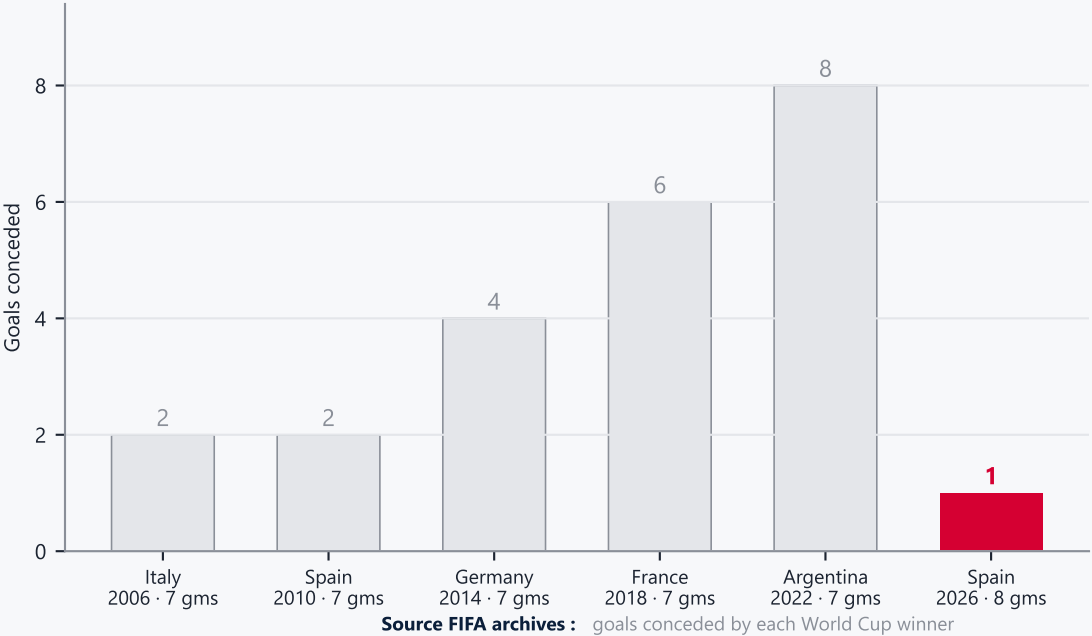
But the numbers also explain why Spain would have been favourites in the final that never was. England conceded 12 goals from 9.3 expected; Spain conceded one from 2.4. England kept two clean sheets to Spain's seven. And England's goals ran through two men (65%), a dependency Spain's system is built to break — a press that won the ball in the attacking third 6.1 times a match against England's 3.4, starving the supply line long before it reaches the finisher.



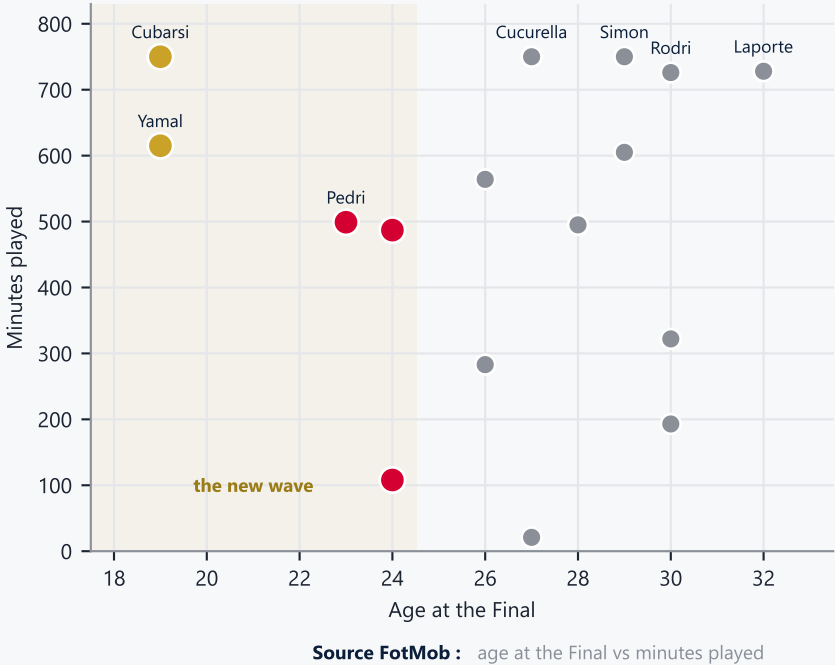
Source FotMob : both teams, 8 matches each

Source FIFA / ESPN / Olympics.com : England's eight matches

The stingiest champion of the modern era



Two generations, one core



26.4

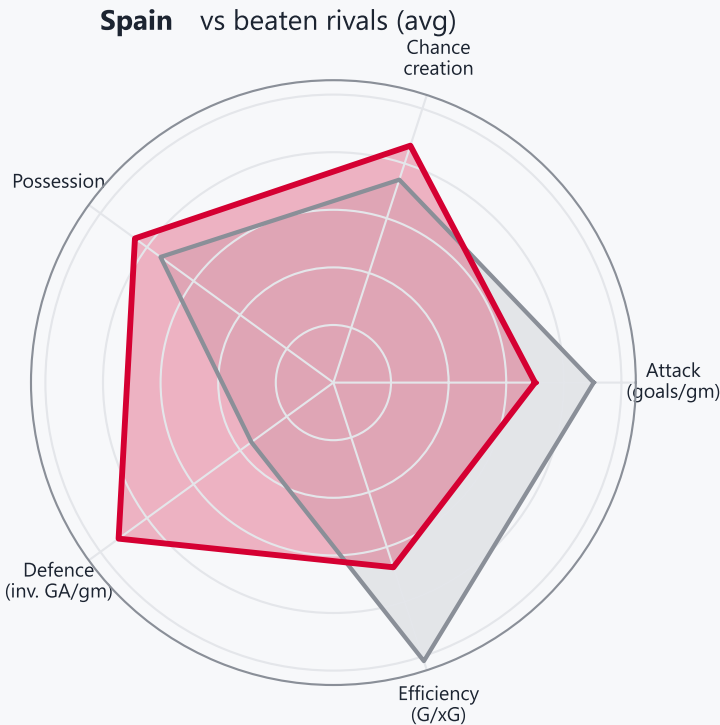
minutes-weighted average age

19

age of Cubarsi & Yamal — both starters

One goal conceded is not just this tournament's best defence — it is the best defensive campaign by any World Cup winner in the modern era, and Spain did it across eight matches where every champion before them played seven. Italy 2006 and Spain 2010, the previous benchmarks, conceded two; the last two champions before 2026 conceded six and eight.

The squad structure explains why this may only be the beginning. The minutes were carried by two generations at once: a prime core aged 26-30 (Rodri, Oyarzabal, Simon, Cucurella) and a teenage spine — Cubarsi and Yamal, both 19, both starters in the Final. A minutes-weighted average age of 26.4 with the two youngest players locked into the XI is the profile of a team built to defend this title in 2030.



Source FotMob : normalised per-match profile

RODRI

Golden Ball — best player

U. SIMON

Golden Glove — 7 clean sheets

P. CUBARSI

Best Young Player — age 19

M. OYARZABAL

5 goals — Spain top scorer

L. YAMAL

4.0 dribbles per 90 — 98th percentile

F. TORRES

Scored the Final winner, 106'

Five reasons Spain won

1. Elite defence

One goal conceded in eight games; xG against never above 0.7 (FotMob).
2. Shared goals

Eleven players with a goal or assist; four knockout winners from four scorers.
3. Midfield control

51%+ possession in every match (avg 64%), run by Golden Ball winner Rodri.
4. Squad depth

Merino scored two knockout winners in just 193 minutes off the bench.
5. Big-game nerve

Portugal, Belgium, France, Argentina beaten in succession.